When We Come to It, We Must Do Something

By Maya Angelou, Neil Hilborn and Rudy Francisco

Human Family by Maya Angelou (Pg 218-219)

I note the obvious differences
in the human family.
Some of us are serious,
some thrive on comedy.

Some declare their lives are lived
as true profundity,
and others claim they really live
the real reality.

The variety of our skin tones
can confuse, bemuse, delight,
brown and pink and beige and purple,
tan and blue and white.

I've sailed upon the seven seas
and stopped in every land,
I've seen the wonders of the world
not yet one common man.

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We love and lose in China,
we weep on England's moors,
and laugh and moan in Guinea,
and thrive on Spanish shores.

We seek success in Finland,
are born and die in Maine.
In minor ways we differ,
in major we're the same.

I note the obvious differences
between each sort and type,
but we are more alike, my friends,
than we are unalike.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maya Angelou
Book: The Complete Poetry of Maya Angelou, Pg 218-219
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INTRODUCTION

I watch the news. I hear the stories of the homeless, the migrants fleeing war-torn countries, the women fighting once again for equal rights. And I feel sad. And angry. And hopeless. But feeling is only one step.

*The ability to connect empathically with others—to feel with them, to care about their well-being, and to **act** with*

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*compassion—is critical to our lives, helping us to get along, work more effectively, and thrive as a society. Once empathy is activated, compassionate **action** is the most logical response.*

*When We Come to It, We Must **Do** Something – A Collection of poetry by Maya Angelou, Neil Hilborn and Rudy Francisco.*

A Brave and Startling Truth by Maya Angelou (Pg 269-271)

We, this people, on a small and lonely planet
Traveling through casual space
Past aloof stars, across the way of indifferent suns
To a destination where all signs tell us
It is possible and imperative that we learn
A brave and startling truth

And when we come to it
To the day of peacemaking
When we release our fingers
From fists of hostility
And allow the pure air to cool our palms

When we come to it
When the curtain falls on the minstrel show of hate
And faces sooted with scorn are scrubbed clean
When battlefields and coliseum
No longer rake our unique and particular sons and daughters

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Up with the bruised and bloody grass
To lie in identical plots in foreign soil

When the rapacious storming of the churches
The screaming racket in the temples have ceased
When the pennants are waving gaily
When the banners of the world tremble
Stoutly in the good, clean breeze

When we come to it
When we let the rifles fall from our shoulders
And children dress their dolls in flags of truce
When land mines of death have been removed
And the aged can walk into evenings of peace
When religious ritual is not perfumed
By the incense of burning flesh
And childhood dreams are not kicked awake
By nightmares of abuse

When we come to it
We, this people, on this wayward, floating body
Created on this earth, of this earth
Have the power to fashion for this earth
A climate where every man and every woman
Can live freely without sanctimonious piety
Without crippling fear

When we come to it
We must confess that we are the possible
We are the miraculous, the true wonder of this world

That is when, and only when
We come to it. “

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maya Angelou
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This is Not the End of the World by Neil Hilborn

I’ve been hearing that the world is ending.
I’ve heard it so much these days, I can either completely ignore it or never leave my house again, that is if I actually left my house for things that don’t directly enable me to keep my house.

See, I’ve been thinking about driving nowhere.
I’ve been thinking about becoming a box inside a locked room inside a dark house at the dark end of the street.

I want to go away until I’m gone.
It takes so much less energy to not exist than it does to exist and get burned.
I’ve been burned so much I’m not me anymore, I’m a stupid puppet version of me.
I’ve got strings that lead to nowhere, nothing is pulling me.
I wish someone would drag my hand out of hiding and sign my name on the dotted line.

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There are days that I cannot find the sun even though it’s right outside my goddamn window, when getting out of bed feels like the key in the doomsday machine, so on those days, this is what I tell myself:
Whatever you’re feeling right now, there is a mathematical certainty that someone else is feeling that exact same thing.
That is not to say you’re not special, this is to say thank god you aren’t special.

I have kissed no one goodnight.
I have launched myself from tall places and hoped no one would catch me.
I have ended relationships because suddenly, I was also exposed.

Isolation is not safety, it is death.
If no one knows you’re alive, you aren’t.
If a tree falls in a forest and no one’s around to hear it, it does make a sound but then that sound is gone.

I’m not saying you will find the meaning of life in other people, I’m saying other people are the life to which you provide the meaning.
See, we’re wrong when we say, “I think therefore I am,” the more we say it, the more it sounds like “I think therefore I will be.”

You cannot think yourself into a full table.
You cannot think and make walls and a roof appear around you.
I have thought and thought myself into corners made of words and nightmares.
And what has it gotten me but more thoughts.
A currency that only buys more currency.

So please, if you want to continue existing, do something.
Learn to make clouds using only your breath.
Build a house even if every wall leans to the left.
Love it anyway, just like a season, just like a child.
Love how you hate yourself sometimes because, goddamn, at least there's still something to hate.

I know how easy it is to think and keep thinking until you're the last person left on earth, until the world becomes no larger than the space between your bed and the light switch.

But I hear the world is ending soon.
When we go, and we're all going to go, I will be part of it.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil Hilborn
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https://everythingandnothingdotin.wordpress.com/2018/04/02/this-is-not-the-end-of-the-world-by-neil-hilborn/
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Complainers by Rudy Francisco (Pg 91-94)

The following are true stories.

May 26th, 2003, Aron Ralston was hiking, a boulder fell on his right hand. He waited four days, then amputated his arm with a pocketknife.

On New Year's Eve, a woman was bungee jumping in Zimbabwe. The cord broke, she then fell into a river and had to swim back to land in crocodile infested waters with a broken collarbone.

Claire Champlin was smashed in the face by a five-pound watermelon being propelled by a slingshot.

Matthew Brobst was hit by a javelin.

David Striegl was punched in the mouth. By a kangaroo.

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The most amazing part about these stories is when asked about the experience they all smiled, shrugged, and said "I guess things could have been worse."

So go ahead. Tell me that you're having a bad day.
Tell me about the traffic. Tell me about your boss. Tell me about the job you've been trying to quit for the past four years. Tell me the morning is just a town house burning to the ground and the snooze button is a fire extinguisher. Tell me the alarm clock stole the keys to your smile, drove it into 7:00 AM, and the crash totaled your happiness.

Tell me! Tell me!
Tell me, how blessed are we to have tragedies so small it can fit on the tips of our tongues?

You see, when Evan lost his legs, he was speechless. When my cousin was assaulted, she didn't speak for forty-eight hours. When my uncle was murdered, we had to send out a search party to find my father's voice.

Most people have no idea that tragedy and silence have the exact same address.

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When your day is a museum of disappointments hanging from events that were outside of your control,

when you find yourself flailing in an ocean of "Why is this happening to me?"

when it feels like your guardian angel put in his two week notice two months ago and just decided not to tell you,

when it feels like God is just a babysitter that's always on the phone,

when you get punched in the esophagus by a fistful of life,

remember that every year two million people die of dehydration so it doesn't matter if the glass is half full or half empty, there's water in the cup.

Drink it and stop complaining.

Muscle is created by repeatedly lifting things that have been designed to weigh us down. So when your shoulders feel heavy, stand up straight and lift your chin – call it exercise.

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When the world crumbles around you, you have to look at the wreckage and then build a new one out of the pieces that are still here.

Remember, you are still here.

The human heart beats approximately four thousand times per hour. Each pulse, each throb, each palpitation is a trophy engraved with the words “You are still alive.”

You are still alive. Act like it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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